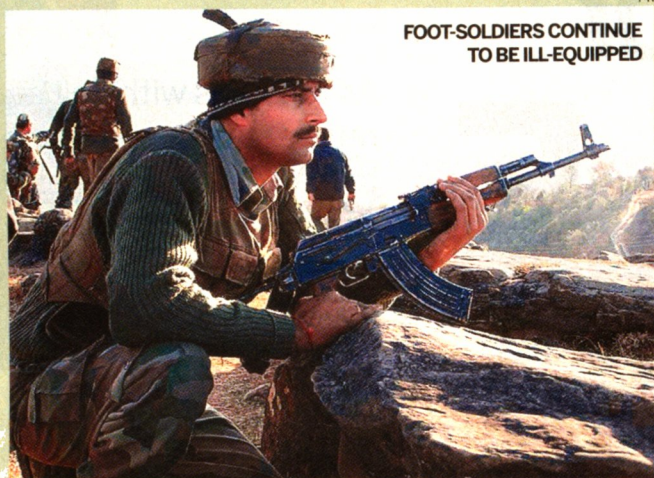




PTI
FOOT-SOLDIERS CONTINUE
TO BE ILL-EQUIPPED

INFANTRY

Wanted: Assault rifles, under-barrel grenade launchers, reflex sights, tactical communication radios.

Worth: Rs 3,700 crore

Status: Tenders floated. Acquisition likely to take between three to four years. Being fast-tracked.

MISSILES

Wanted: 4 regiments of quick-reaction, short-range missiles and medium-range surface-to-air missiles to replace ageing Kvadrat and Osa-AK system.

Worth: Rs 10,500 crore

Status: Tender withdrawn because only one company submitted bid. Delayed by five years.



NO RELIEF FOR THE VINTAGE
KVADRAT MISSILE

Nearly a decade after its Bofors howitzers performed spectacularly during the Kargil war, the army has not bought even one of the 1,860 howitzers it had projected. This year, it will once again restart a five-year evaluation and acquisition process. In the years following Operation Parakram the army propounded its Cold Start battle doctrine which called for using massive firepower—rockets, missiles and long-range guns to offset a near parity of foot-soldiers with Pakistan. Today, the strategy is in place, but the tools are missing. "It is most inappropriate to delay the acquisition of modern 155mm howitzers as only a massive firepower asymmetry can overcome

the lack of deep manoeuvre when land operations are planned under a nuclear umbrella," says Brigadier Gurmeet Kanwal (retired), director of the Centre for Land Warfare Studies.

What has rung alarm bells is Pakistan's rapid acquisition of US technology over the past eight years—anti-tank missile-firing gunships, anti-ship missiles and night-vision devices under the War on Terror—and a steady build-up of Chinese military capabilities. The army's tanks and combat vehicles are night-blind, a critical lapse in an age of short duration, round-the-clock wars. Analysts say the state of modernisation of any military is judged by its equipment profile.

Normally, a military should have 30 per cent state-of-the-art equipment, 40 per cent based on matured technologies and 30 per cent getting closer to obsolescence. "In India the current proportion is close to 15, 35 and 50 per cent, respectively," says defence analyst Major General Mrinal Suman (retired). It is this 50 per cent of the arsenal which sorely needs replacement and that leads to the arm-flailing called fast-track procurement. Consider this: the mainstay of the air defence artillery continues to be the World War II era L-70 ack-ack gun. A tender to replace them was cancelled last year because only one global vendor showed up.

In 2002, the Ministry of Defence codified the DPP into a manual which would guide the government on buying military equipment and eliminate single-vendor situations. Seven years hence, the only items the army has managed to purchase are two artillery regiments each with 12 Smerch long-range rockets and over 300 T-90 battle tanks. Both from Russia as



“The normal process of acquisition takes about two to five years. It is in the national interest to have the needed equipment in a much quicker time-frame.”

GENERAL DEEPAK KAPOOR, *Chief of Army Staff*